INTERVENTION DEVELOPMENT • MRC COMPLEX-INTERVENTION FRAMEWORK: DEVELOPMENT PHASE

Beyond the One-Parent Model: Developing a Shared-Caregiving Digital Single-Session Intervention for School Refusal in China

One caregiver can start—but they should not have to carry school refusal alone.

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Morning Light 晨光一小步 combines a full single-caregiver SSI with a brief, independent second-caregiver pathway to support shared responsibility and more consistent responding.

Design: narrative review + theory building → validation integration model → logic model → working mobile prototype. No participant data yet; this poster reports development outputs, not effects.

1 Why school refusal?

School refusal is an emotionally driven difficulty attending or remaining at school. Chinese longitudinal data show heterogeneous trajectories, with **family functioning** predicting trajectory membership (Yuan & Fu, 2026).

School refusal is not a single problem with a single cause.

Youth ⇄ Family ⇄ School

2 The intervention gap

EXISTING PARENT-FOCUSED MODEL

Parent seeks help → One primary participating caregiver → Stress regulation • parenting skills • accommodation • school contact

But what about the other caregiver?

Online parent programmes for school refusal (ISAAC; PiP-Ed+) show promise but generally centre on one primary participant. PiP-Ed+ parents named **greater co-parent involvement** and **separate log-ins and goals** as desirable improvements (Lester et al., 2026; Smout et al., 2025).

3 From pressure and accommodation to validation

Caregivers often move between pressure and accommodation. Through the lens of the **invalidating environment** (Linehan, 1993), each misses a different half of support.

PRESSURE

“You have to go.”

Expectation ✓ • Validation ×

Possible message received: *“My distress does not matter.”*

EXCESSIVE ACCOMMODATION

“Then stay home.”

Validation ✓ • Confidence ×

Possible message received: *“You cannot cope with this.”*

SUPPORTIVE RESPONSE

“I know this feels really hard. I believe you can face it with support. Let’s choose one small next step together.”

Validation ✓ • Confidence ✓ • Expectation ✓ • Youth participation ✓

Support means validating the young person’s distress while communicating confidence in their capacity to cope.

Why a single-session intervention?

An umbrella review of 24 systematic reviews (415 unique SSI trials) found most reviews reporting at least one significant positive effect (Schleider et al., 2025). A review of parent-focused SSIs (10 studies, 1,872 participants) found preliminary benefits for parental mental health, parenting and acceptability, and called for more rigorous trials (Wheeler & King, 2026).

4 Validation integration model: a two-level core

CAREGIVER LEVEL

School refusal increases family stress → Caregiving responsibility may become concentrated; responses may diverge → **SHARED CAREGIVING** share one concrete task • reduce the load on one caregiver • keep a broadly consistent supportive direction

↓ creates conditions for

CAREGIVER–ADOLESCENT LEVEL

VALIDATE EXPERIENCE × COMMUNICATE CONFIDENCE → Maintain expectations + youth chooses the next feasible step → **Gradual school re-engagement**

Stabilize the caregiving system → support caregiver–adolescent co-regulation → support gradual school re-engagement. “×”: both must be present together.

5 Morning Light 晨光一小步

A 25–30-minute self-guided mobile SSI for caregivers of school-refusing youth, reached through school, online and clinic-waitlist entry points.

PRIMARY CAREGIVER PATHWAY • FULL SSI

1. **Notice my own alarm.** “What am I feeling and fearing right now?”
2. **Identify my response tendency.** Pressure / accommodation / shifting / supportive
3. **Pause before responding.** 30-second regulation exercise when distress is high
4. **Learn supportive responding.** Validate experience × communicate confidence, maintain expectations
5. **Safety triage.** Difficult but safe → graded approach; possible real harm → safety first, professional or school support
6. **Choose one feasible re-engagement step.** The young person helps select it
7. **Shared-caregiving invitation →** name one task another caregiver could share

A 3-MINUTE PATHWAY FOR ANOTHER CAREGIVER

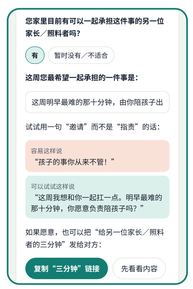
A father, mother, grandparent or other important caregiver enters separately.

1 • **Share your own understanding.** What is hardest for the young person right now?

2 • **Choose one supportive message.** It recognizes distress and communicates confidence.

3 • **Take one concrete task this week.** Morning support, school contact, evening check-in, or one small return-to-school step.

Not mandatory: if only one caregiver is available, the main SSI remains complete.



Shared caregiving, step 7

The caregiver names one thing they most need help with this week and turns a blaming line into an invitation.

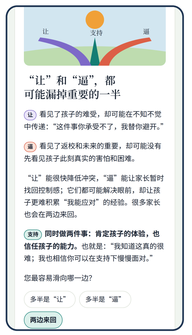


Second-caregiver inclusion

Another available caregiver gets a brief, independent pathway rather than being required to complete the full intervention.

Shared direction: “We see that this is hard, and we believe you can face it step by step.”

6 What we built



Tailored self-reflection. Caregivers identify their typical tendency; later examples adapt to it.



Safety triage. Gradual approach only when the situation is difficult but reasonably safe.



Active skill practice. Rewrite a habitual line with validation, confidence and expectations.



Actionable takeaway. A personalized weekly action card summarizes the new response and next step.

Explore the prototype

Scan to explore Morning Light, an interactive prototype of a mobile single-session intervention for caregivers of youth experiencing school refusal.

Demo only • No personal data are collected or uploaded

In the development stage; not yet user-tested or evaluated for efficacy. Not a substitute for professional assessment or treatment.

7 Development outputs

- ✓ Evidence synthesis completed
- ✓ Components mapped to hypothesized mechanisms
- ✓ Independent second-caregiver pathway implemented
- ✓ Two-level intervention model specified
- ✓ 25–30 min mobile SSI developed
- ✓ Safety triage + personalized action card implemented

8 Testable next step

Co-design Parents, grandparents, professionals → **Usability testing** Comprehension, burden, navigation, cultural fit → **Feasibility trial** Recruitment, completion, 4-week retention, acceptability

Primary feasibility outcomes also include **second-caregiver reach and uptake**. Preliminary measures: accommodation, pressure, caregiver distress tolerance, coparenting / shared responsibility, attendance, youth anxiety and distress.

Future test: can the second-caregiver pathway add value?

Families with two reachable caregivers: **primary-caregiver SSI only** vs **SSI + direct platform invitation to the second caregiver** (the help-seeking parent does not carry the invitation). Outcomes: second-caregiver participation, shared responsibility, caregiver burden, consistency of supportive responding, attendance, youth distress.

Morning Light turns this principle into a testable shared-caregiving intervention architecture.

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